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February 4, 2026

Dear UCLA Distinguished Teaching Award Selection Committee Members,

On behalf of the Institute of the Environment & Sustainability, I am pleased to offer my strongest recommendation for **Sebastián Solarte-Caicedo** for the Teaching Assistant Award. Sebastián is an exceptional teacher and is one of the most dedicated and engaged graduate students we have had in our Ph.D. program.

One of Sebastián's greatest strengths is his ability to recognize barriers to student learning and respond with practical, evidence-based solutions. In courses without discussion sections, he transforms office hours into active learning environments, incorporating techniques such as think–pair–share, case studies, and peer teaching to promote engagement and deeper conceptual understanding. Just as importantly, he emphasizes clear expectations, transparent grading, and consistent communication, which helps reduce student anxiety and creates a learning environment grounded in trust and respect. Student feedback consistently reflects the success of these approaches, highlighting both increased confidence and intellectual engagement. He cares deeply about his students and they consistently express their appreciation for his dedication and support.

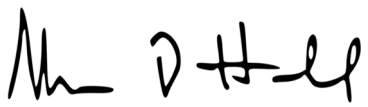
Sebastián goes well beyond required TA responsibilities to create new learning opportunities for students. Over several years, he has mentored undergraduates, supported student research collaborations, and facilitated extracurricular learning spaces focused on environmental issues and justice-oriented perspectives. A particularly impressive example was his success in securing funding through the 100,000 Strong in the Americas Innovation Fund to support a student-led, community-engaged senior practicum connecting UCLA students with peers in Colombia. This project allowed students—many from underrepresented backgrounds and participating in international research for the first time—to apply classroom learning to real-world sustainability challenges in both local and global contexts.

Equally notable is Sebastián's commitment to improving his teaching through ongoing professional development. He actively engages with resources from the Teaching and Learning Center and the Center for Education Innovation & Learning in the Sciences. He also participates in the American Association of Geographers' Working Group on Teaching Energy Geographies. He brings what he learns back into the classroom. As one example, after organizing a focus group to gather student feedback across multiple offerings of a course, he collaborated with faculty to refine the course

and developed an innovative assignment addressing generative AI and digital literacy—an approach that students found both timely and meaningful.

It is a privilege to write in support of Sebastián, whose passion for teaching and genuine care for students have made a lasting impact on our program. His kindness and thoughtful guidance foster a sense of belonging in the classroom, inspiring students to not only excel academically but also to grow personally and professionally. Sebastián's unwavering commitment to their success is evident, and his ability to connect with students on a human level makes him an invaluable member of our community. I enthusiastically recommend Sebastián Solarte-Caicedo for this award.

Sincerely,



Alex Hall, Ph.D.
Director, UCLA Institute of the Environment and Sustainability

2026 UCLA Distinguished Teaching Awards
Teaching Assistant Category
Sebastián Solarte-Caicedo

# Self-Statement

In my work as a Teaching Assistant (TA), I have prioritized the creation of comprehensive tools that allow students to access interactive learning experiences, and ultimately develop critical, systemic, and justice-oriented thinking. However, creating such an impact can be challenging for TAs in courses without discussions sections. For these contexts, I have developed creative solutions such as transforming office hours into collaborative problem-solving spaces, securing funds to create international experiential opportunities, and designing innovative assignments. Drawing from insights from the American Association of Geographers' Working Group on Teaching Energy Geographies and the pedagogical resources offered by the Teaching and Learning Center and the Center for Education Innovation & Learning in the Sciences, this statement demonstrates the possibilities for creating inclusive, student-centered experiences through evidence-based practices in contexts without traditional discussion sections.

## Establishing clear frameworks for all students

The first step is to design a structured framework that can be understood and anticipated by all students, regardless of the degree of interaction we have throughout the quarter. This includes two pillars:

a) Offering students a rich conceptual learning experience by supporting their mastery of course content while fostering a critical understanding of it. I invite students to attend regular and additional office hours, which I transform into active learning spaces by implementing small-scale, student-centered activities such as case studies or peer teaching. Through dialogue and reflection, I encourage students to go beyond and consider the broader implications of the course for their personal and academic trajectories.

b) Treating students with care and empathy. Understanding student needs and preferences requires the establishment of clear rubrics, consistent communication channels, and safe

mechanisms to address potential issues. By reducing anxiety around expectations for success, I help create conditions for healthier engagement with the course.

As *Teaching Artifact #1*, I include a selection of comments from SET surveys that showcase specific examples of how these pillars inform my teaching practices.

**Creating new opportunities beyond the classroom**

In the absence of discussion sections, I actively seek to create additional spaces for students who are curious and interested in exploring. Over the past four years, I have mentored students in navigating their research interests, invited them to collaborate with me on my own research as co-authors, and facilitated an extracurricular student group that met to discuss environmental issues not typically covered in their environmental science courses (see *Teaching Artifact #2*).

These opportunities become particularly meaningful when they allow students to take an active role in shaping their own learning experiences. The most significant example was securing a grant from the 100,000 Strong in the Americas Innovation Fund (see *Teaching Artifact # 3*). I initiated a collaboration between UCLA and the Antioquia School of Engineering to study community-scale renewable energy initiatives in East Los Angeles and Medellín (Colombia). We designed this project as a community-engaged, student-led, cross-cultural learning experience that enabled eight UCLA students and six Colombian students from underrepresented backgrounds to have their first international research experience, travel abroad, and apply classroom concepts about the energy transition in real-world contexts.

Ultimately organized as a senior practicum, this project advanced UCLA's Strategic Goals of local engagement and global reach and generated outcomes that contribute to evidence-based learning practices. These outcomes are currently under review in the Journal of Geography in Higher Education.

**Innovating and adapting teaching practices**

Finally, I have collaborated with professors on the design of inclusive syllabuses that integrate formative assessment practices and center student feedback. In summer 2025, I organized a focus

group with students from four cohorts of ENVIRON 155 to identify areas for improvement. One key recommendation was to address more explicitly the disruptions caused by Generative AI (GenAI). In response, I proposed an innovative assignment aimed at developing critical digital literacy around GenAI (see *Teaching Artifact #4*). Students wrote a short analysis, generated a comparable response using GenAI, and then critically compared the two. Given our department's focus on environmental studies, I further suggested using a chatbot that tracks the energy use associated with each query. We revisited the assignment twice over the quarter and students consistently identified it as an effective way to ground what can otherwise feel like an abstract debate about GenAI's environmental and pedagogical impacts.

**Conclusion**

My experience as a TA has reinforced my belief that effective teaching is fundamentally about fostering trust and creating the conditions for all students to succeed. In the absence of discussion sections, TAs can play a meaningful role in establishing clear learning frameworks, creating opportunities beyond the classroom, and collecting student feedback to support the development of more inclusive and equitable syllabuses. Through these efforts, TAs can become active agents in fostering the development of critical, just, and holistic students.

2026 UCLA Distinguished Teaching Awards
Teaching Assistant Category
Sebastián Solarte-Caicedo

# Statement of Teaching

*The first lecture isn't taught, whereas the last one is not received*. This is one of the most memorable traditions of the school I attended. During the first and the last day of the semester, this tradition encouraged professors and students to talk about something other than the course, and most professors used this space to share words of wisdom. The most impactful advice I received came from a labor law professor who opened my eyes to what college was about: "Despite what you might think right now," he said, "our goal with these classes is not to transform you into experts on these subjects or help you get good grades. Teachers are storytellers, sharing with you a series of ideas and anecdotes, hoping that one of them will resonate differently in your brains and hearts. And when this happens, do not let it go. Follow it. Pull that thread. At the end of the day, it is better to be the person who followed their passion than the one who figured out how to get the best grades or the most prestigious job.".

I cannot underscore how influential this lesson was for me. I have carried these words for more than a decade, and they have influenced not only my decision to pursue a career in academia but, more importantly, my commitment to exploring my passion for teaching. As I discuss in the following paragraphs, my beliefs, values, and goals regarding teaching are primarily focused on creating a supportive and justice-oriented environment in which students can explore and experiment, while remaining curious and critical about the ways their work can impact their communities and the planet.

At the core of my teaching philosophy is the goal of ensuring that students develop a systemic yet grounded perspective on the subjects they are studying. At the UCLA Institute of the Environment and Sustainability, most undergraduates are seeking the tools and skills needed to address the most pressing socio-ecological issues facing the world, such as climate change. However, the interdisciplinary nature of these issues requires students to pivot between STEM, social sciences, and humanities courses. As Teaching Assistants (TAs), it is our responsibility to help them make the connections necessary to develop a comprehensive understanding across these disciplines. This is particularly relevant in small departments like ours, where TAs have the privilege of working with the same students over several years across different classes, helping

them move from understanding Earth systems to decoding regulatory frameworks, from designing cost-benefit analyses to developing communications campaigns. In this context, TAs become a common thread between subjects that might otherwise seem disconnected.

Active learning and student-centered strategies are central to this process. While TAs can initially help make these connections explicit, my goal is for students, by the end of their time at UCLA, to autonomously recognize that environmental careers are inherently complex, collaborative, and shaped by trade-offs. I have found peer-teaching and case-study methodologies particularly effective for integrating concepts across courses, even within brief discussions, as they mirror real-world scenarios. Through these activities, students learn that addressing socio-environmental crises is not about identifying quick fixes, but about collaboratively developing a holistic understanding of complex problems and the range of possible responses.

Despite the benefits of active learning strategies, some students may require alternative arrangements and accommodations to make the most out of their academic experiences. Paying attention to these differences is, for me, a matter of justice and a core value guiding the design of equitable and inclusive courses. I believe that justice-centered pedagogical approaches are more likely to encourage students to adopt justice-oriented professional and personal practices. Reflecting on my own positionality as an international student for whom English is a second language, I am attentive to avoiding strategies that may intimidate students, discourage participation, or reproduce structural barriers and injustices within the classroom. This includes recognizing that not all students feel comfortable in environments where active learning is the dominant mode. Accordingly, I provide multiple avenues for engagement, such as one-on-one meetings, and virtual spaces, to ensure all students can participate meaningfully.

Developing these strategies has required ongoing professional development beyond UCLA's TA mandatory training. I have actively engaged with online resources from the Teaching and Learning Center and the Center for Education Innovation & Learning in the Sciences covering topics such as active learning and inclusive teaching, teaching during difficult times, or alternative assessment and grading strategies, which I have actively discussed with my academic

advisor. Additionally, my participation in the American Association of Geographers' Working Group on Teaching Energy Geographies has provided valuable insights into discipline-specific teaching challenges, such as incorporating generative AI into environmental education. This commitment to continuous learning ensures that my teaching remains grounded in current evidence-based practices while responsive to emerging pedagogical questions.

The points outlined above are encompassed in my belief that TA work is an act of care, empathy, and respect above all. Students are not simply defined by the assignments they produce and the grades they earn. As TAs, we should encourage students to care for their mental and physical health as a prerequisite for success in their academic endeavors. While it is not our role to anticipate and resolve every possible scenario, it is our responsibility to adopt clear practices that acknowledge the heterogeneous academic and personal pathways students may be navigating, and to remain available to discuss situations in which additional support may be helpful, from recommending the inclusion of UCLA’s well-being resources explicitly in the syllabuses, such as Be Well Bruin and Counseling & Psychological Services, to advocating for the students when tensions arise between them and the professor.

I am proud to say that the teaching artifacts attached to this application show that my work as a TA demonstrates that it is possible to commit to rigorous and demanding academic work while also cultivating a nurturing environment in which students feel comfortable exploring and experimenting. By committing to justice-centered and inclusive teaching practices that allow students to actively develop critical thinking, I aim to create opportunities for students to find what truly moves them and become holistic, well-rounded, and humane professionals.

2026 UCLA Distinguished Teaching Awards
Teaching Assistant Category
Sebastián Solarte-Caicedo

# Teaching Artifacts

## *Teaching Artifact #1*: Student Evaluation of Teaching (SET)

These SET snippets show how my approach to teaching revolves around creating a rigorous learning experience that acknowledges the humanness of the students.

> Sebastián was an amazing TA who was the backbone of this course. He was always very communicative, especially wonderful given how the course was somewhat in the middle of a redesign and assignments were shifting slightly or being decided between in person or online. The nuclear debate and final projects he organized both turned out great, and the course overall ran pretty smoothly because of him. His lecture about his research was also incredibly interesting, and his passion and expertise in the energy field were very clear.

- Sebastian was a great TA and very helpful in his grading and feedback! I've had him for other courses as well and he had always been very concerned with student learning and is an engaging TA. Despite this course not having an actual discussion section component, he was very interactive and always replied quickly to emails. His guest lecturer presentation was very interesting as well and I found incredibly interesting. Overall a great TA and would definitely take a course again with him in the future!

- Sebastián is amongst one of the best TAs I have ever met throughout my time at UCLA. Not only is he extremely well-informed about course topics, but he consistently seeks ways to get students involved in the topics learned in class, be it through further readings, research opportunities, and more. The lecture he shared in the final week of class is amongst one of the most thought-provoking lectures shared throughout this entire course. Unfortunately, I am unable to pinpoint any real weaknesses.

- Sebastian is a wonderful TA. I went to Office Hours a couple of times and really enjoyed our discussions and time flew. Sebastian even started a discussion group for interested student to continue after the quarter ends. I am really excited to be able to continue talking with Sebastian about the Energy Transition and other sustainability-related topics. Sebastian lectured to us once in class and it was extremely valuable to hear about the work that he is doing. His area of Energy Justice is an important one, and he showed us a facet of it that many of us had never seen before. He is obviously very knowledgeable about and familiar with the material.

- Sebastian was the best TA I've ever had. He presented a guest lecture near the end of the course and it was absolutely amazing. His research in Colombia is fascinating and he is so well-articulated. He goes above and beyond to accomodate students, answer emails, and make sure we all understand the material. In addition, since there was no sections in this class, he organized a discussion for anyone who wanted to delve deeper into alternative climate solutions. We meet every other week on his own time. This shows he persoanlly cares about the students and our futures in the environmental field. I am very grateful for his dedication and willingness to share his knowledge and time.

- We were so lucky with our TA this quarter. Sebastian is incredibly knowledgeable about the course topics and you can see that he is eager to learn more from others. He is very communicative and has responded to my questions quickly and clearly. He is very helpful and has taught me a lot throughout the quarter. I am inspired by his initiative to go out into the world and perform hands on research as well as attend panels and conferences related to his work -- it seems as if he really understands how to be a lifelong learner.

- Sebastian is just a great person overall. He is knowledgeable, understanding, and caring for student learning and well-being. He makes learning fun and continues to feed new knowledge or answer questions to the best of his ability. Additionally, his amiability makes me feel welcomed and safe.

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Sebastián is a truly excellent TA. He offered plenty of office hours, with extra appointments and review sessions before exams. He responded promptly to emails and demonstrated a genuine interest in helping students understand the material and succeed. Plus, he is incredibly knowledgeable about the course topics and managed to answer all my questions thoroughly.

- Sebastian is the nicest, most dedicated and the most helpful TA I have ever had at UCLA. He is always understanding and it is clear he is very knowledgeable about the course material. He offered extra office hours before exams which was very helpful and he always went over the homework in detail which honestly saved my grade. I don't think I would have succeeded in this course without him, so I am so appreciative of his hard work in supporting his students! Sometimes his explanations are very lengthy but it is helpful for my comprehension. Something that could have been nice for this class would be having sample questions because it was hard to know what to expect for the multiple choice sections in exams.

- Sebastián was an exceptional TA this quarter as he navigated a series of quick developments and changes to the course format. He treated the students with compassion and understanding, and ensured a secure and supportive learning environment.

Sebastian was an outstanding teaching assistant. He genuinely cares about the students' learning, which is evident in his efforts to support them. I appreciate the helpful comments he provides on graded assignments, as well as his approachability outside of class. He is always willing to listen to students and assist them. His mastery of the course content is also great, and I thoroughly enjoyed his contributions and guidance to the group project meetings.

- Sebastián is really nice. He is so caring, responsible and helpful, and also excels in his work. As a visiting student I found the course challenging and also encountered some IT problems at the first few weeks. Sebastián encouraged me to find my pace and finally I was able to keep up. He is always willing to help, spending his time answering our emails and giving feedbacks to our homework. I really appreciated it.

- Sebastian is an incredible TA. I joined the course two weeks into the quarter and he was super supportive and helpful in catching me up; I ended up not feeling like I missed anything. He is super knowledgable and passionate about the topics discussed, and also a very kind and helpful person. I always enjoyed labs with him, and if I had questions about the topic unrelated to class, he always had interesting responses. He was a very effective communicator, he always responded to emails in a timely and helpful manner. Overall, a very engaging and interesting TA and person.

- I had the privilege of being a student in a course led by Sebastian, a remarkable teaching assistant who truly exemplifies dedication and passion for education. Throughout the semester, Sebastian's commitment to student learning shone brightly, surpassing even that of the professors. From the outset, it was evident that Sebastian genuinely cared about our understanding and growth. He went above and beyond to ensure that each student grasped the concepts being taught, taking the time to explain material in various ways until everyone felt confident. His patience was endless, and his enthusiasm infectious, making even the most complex topics approachable and engaging. Drawing from his own experiences and expertise, he brought relevance and depth to the course material, bridging the gap between theory and application seamlessly. I found myself learning more from Sebastian's anecdotes and demonstrations than from the prescribed textbooks or lectures.

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- Teaching Assistant was very passionate about the course content and found ways to engage the students through connecting course content to its social implications. Created an open and productive environment for learning, was very organized, and challenged students to think about global implications beyond the scope of the course and connecting back to it as well.

## Teaching Artifacts

### Teaching Artifact #2: Mentorship, co-authorships, and extra-curricular discussion groups with students

a) Students Fiorella Hunter and Vedika Mathur expressed interest in learning more about my research, so I invited them to collaborate with me and co-author this article for the 2024 Let Communities Lead Report. The four co-author, Sol Viviana Zapata Alfonso, is a Colombian community leader with whom I have been conducting my doctoral research, which means that the two undergraduates also learned about the importance of conducting community-based participatory research.



*Associative Energy: Palmor's Community-Led Hydroelectric Success*

Learning from challenges of new electricity infrastructure builds adaptive capacities, to successfully operate and govern the community owned energy project for more than three decades.

**Electropalmor in a nutshell**

Electropalmor is a community-owned nonprofit association dedicated to providing electricity in Palmor, a town in the Sierra Nevada de Santa Marta in Colombia (Electropalmor, 2024). This association stands out nationally, since they have been independently administering, operating, and maintaining a small hydroelectric plant since the early 1990s without any major support from external actors. The ~620 Palmoreños who receive the electricity own Electropalmor, make decisions through c
and can be elected to manage
part of its board of directors.

**The origins of Palmor**

The town of Palmor was found
following the displacement of c
scale farmers) fleeing violence b
and Liberal factions in Colombi
2024). These migrants found th
ideal place to continue their far
it was familiar to most campesi
quickly became the primary ecc
mor (Opinión Caribe, 2017). M
a key role in Palmor's social stru
outside organizations (especiall

Story 1: Palmor, Sierra

Authors:
Sol Viviana Zapata Alfonso[a], Fiorella Hunter[b], Vedika Mathur[c], and Sebastián Solarte-Caicedo[d]

[a] Electropalmor

[b] Institute of the Environment and Sustainability, University of California, Los Angeles (UCLA), USA

[c] Department of Geography, University of California, Los Angeles (UCLA), USA

[d] Institute of the Environment and Sustainability, University of California, Los Angeles (UCLA), USA & Pontificia Universidad Javeriana, Colombia

Website:
https://www.ioes.ucla.edu/

Photo credit:
(1.1; 1.2; 1.3; 1.4) Sebastián Solarte-Caicedo; (1.5) Adriana Sanguino

b) Student Eileen Harsono expressed interest in learning how to conduct literature reviews for her upcoming job at a consulting firm, so we brainstormed together a project that merged my research topic and her methodological interests. The result was a co-authored a paper currently under review by the Journal of Latin American Geographies.

MS #1849: Submission received for Journal of Latin American Geography External

**Editors of Journal of Latin American Geography** <editors-jlag-1849@dclsu.bepress.com>
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A new submission for Journal of Latin American Geography has been uploaded by "Sebastián Solarte-Caicedo" <sebsolarte@ucla.edu>.

The authors are:
"Sebastián Solarte-Caicedo" <sebsolarte@ucla.edu>
"Eileen Harsono" <eileentracy7@gmail.com>
The title is:
"Epistemologías de la Pobreza Energética: una Revisión Crítica de la Literatura sobre los Territorios no Interconectados en Colombia"

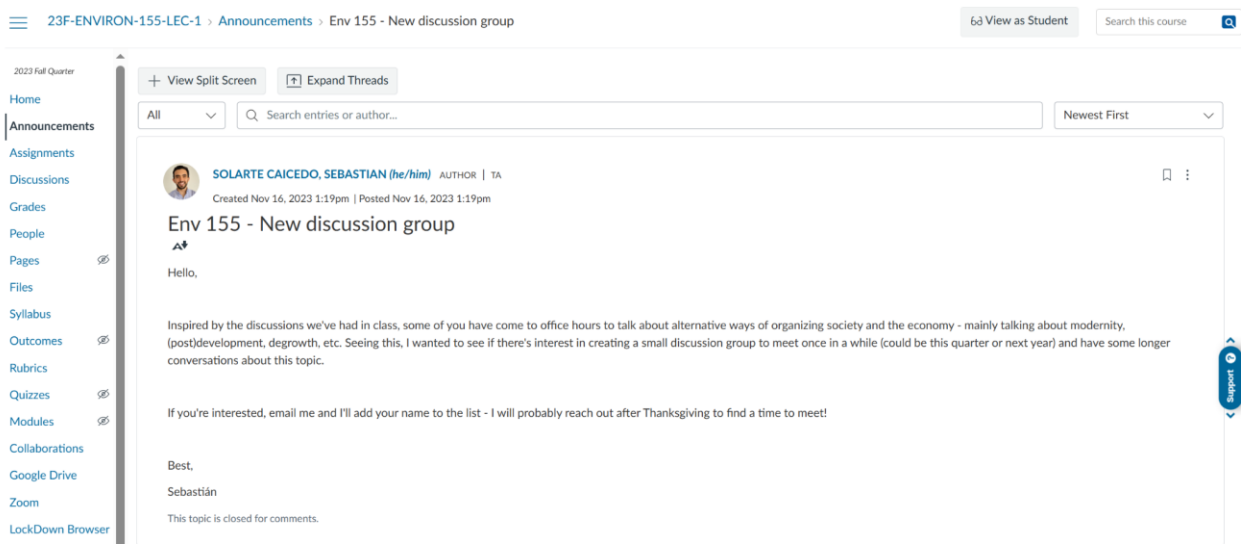
The keywords are:
pobreza energética, Colombia, sostenibilidad, transición energética justa, revisión sistemática de literatura
The disciplines are:
Anthropology | Critical and Cultural Studies | Environmental Studies | Geography | Latin American History | Latin American Studies | Political Science | Public Affairs, Public Policy and Public Administration | Race, Ethnicity and Post-Colonial Studies

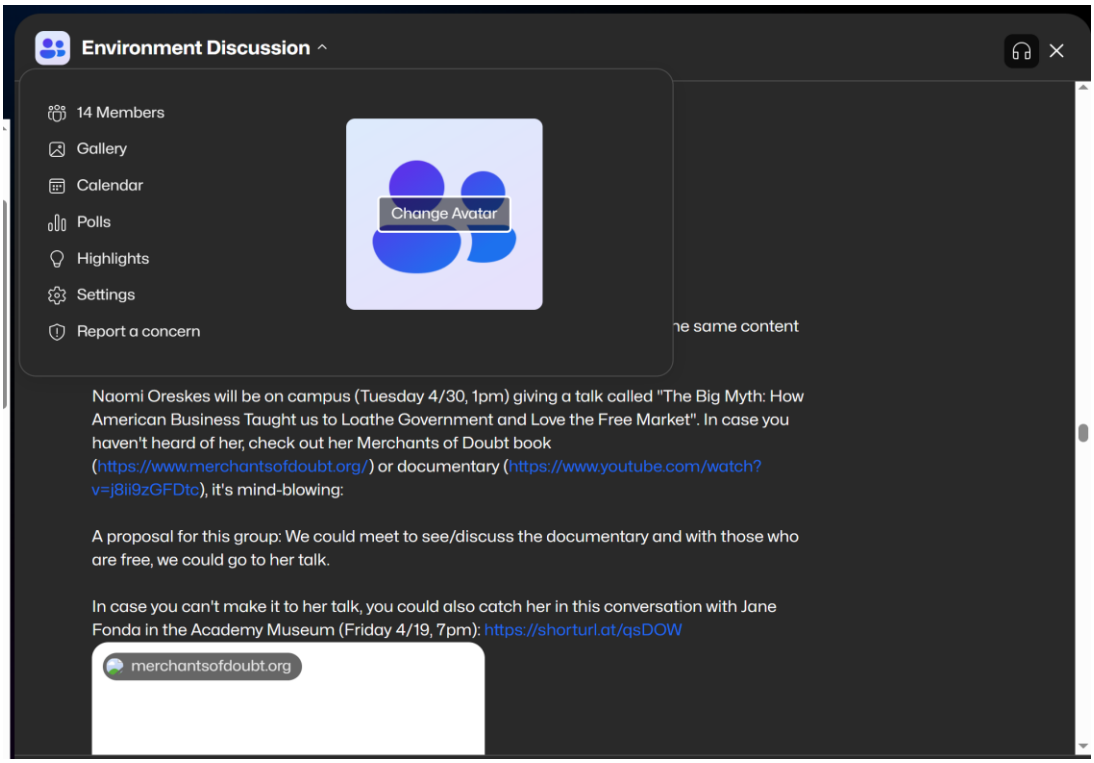
The submission has been assigned #1849. Please refer to this number in any correspondence related to the submission.

Authors may check the status of the submission, submit revisions, and contact editors via the following link:

https://repository.lsu.edu/cgi/preview.cgi?article=1849&context=jlag

c) After working with a very proactive and participative group of students in ENVIRON 155, I extended an invitation to join an extra-curricular group to discuss environmental issues. The screenshots (below) show the Bruin Learn invitation, as well as the GroupMe used during by the group (ultimately composed of 13 students and me).



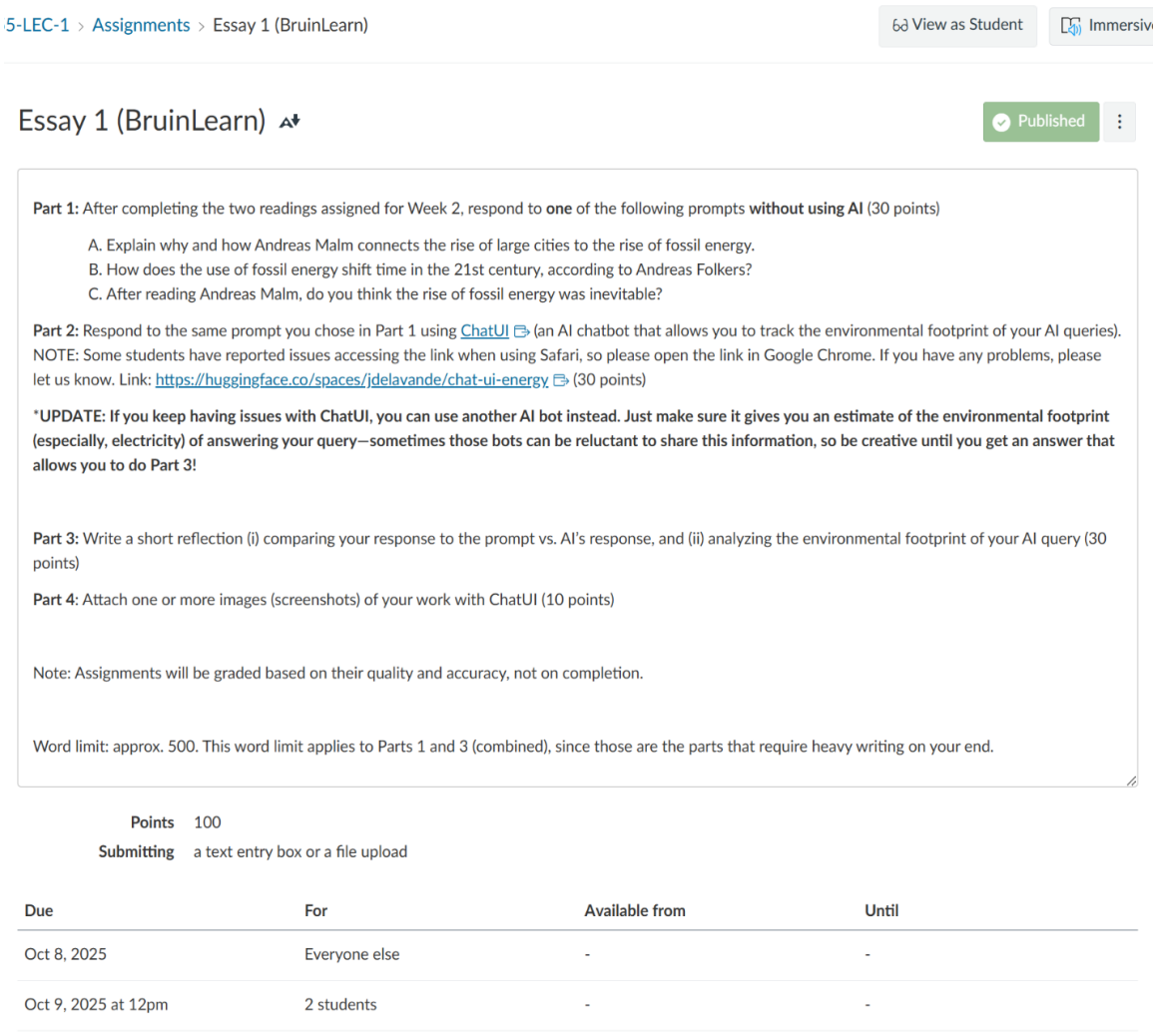



# Teaching Artifacts

## Teaching Artifact #3: GenAI exercise

Drawing on feedback from a focus group conducted in the summer of 2025 with former ENVIRON 155 students, I proposed a GenAI assignment aimed at fostering critical digital literacy by shifting away from outright bans and toward a discussion centered on student agency and learning.

a) The instructions of the assignment (see screenshot below) show in detail the structure of the exercise:



5-LEC-1 › Assignments › Essay 1 (BruinLearn)

View as Student | Immersiv

Essay 1 (BruinLearn)

Published

**Part 1:** After completing the two readings assigned for Week 2, respond to **one** of the following prompts **without using AI** (30 points)

A. Explain why and how Andreas Malm connects the rise of large cities to the rise of fossil energy.
B. How does the use of fossil energy shift time in the 21st century, according to Andreas Folkers?
C. After reading Andreas Malm, do you think the rise of fossil energy was inevitable?

**Part 2:** Respond to the same prompt you chose in Part 1 using ChatUI (an AI chatbot that allows you to track the environmental footprint of your AI queries). NOTE: Some students have reported issues accessing the link when using Safari, so please open the link in Google Chrome. If you have any problems, please let us know. Link: https://huggingface.co/spaces/jdelavande/chat-ui-energy (30 points)

***UPDATE: If you keep having issues with ChatUI, you can use another AI bot instead. Just make sure it gives you an estimate of the environmental footprint (especially, electricity) of answering your query—sometimes those bots can be reluctant to share this information, so be creative until you get an answer that allows you to do Part 3!**

**Part 3:** Write a short reflection (i) comparing your response to the prompt vs. AI's response, and (ii) analyzing the environmental footprint of your AI query (30 points)

**Part 4:** Attach one or more images (screenshots) of your work with ChatUI (10 points)

Note: Assignments will be graded based on their quality and accuracy, not on completion.

Word limit: approx. 500. This word limit applies to Parts 1 and 3 (combined), since those are the parts that require heavy writing on your end.

**Points** 100
**Submitting** a text entry box or a file upload

| Due | For | Available from | Until |
|---|---|---|---|
| Oct 8, 2025 | Everyone else | - | - |
| Oct 9, 2025 at 12pm | 2 students | - | - |

b) The answers provided by students to Part 3 (see an example in screenshot below) confirmed the adequacy of this assignment to foster critical thinking about the environmental and pedagogical implications of GenAI.

**Part 3: Write a short reflection (i) comparing your response to the prompt vs. AI's response, and (ii) analyzing the environmental footprint of your AI query (30 points)**

**(i)** In my response, I tried to build out a thorough answer based on Malm's writing by including an introduction, history, implications and connection, and then a conclusion. The AI response breaks down Malm's connection of the rise of cities and fossil energy into specific sections with labeled subheadings. I wanted to focus with more of a historical argument emphasizing the shift and why it happened. The AI is more broad and general speaking much more on what happened rather than why.

**(ii)** Watching the Watt-hours increase as the response generated was a bit of a jarring experience. I always hear about how much energy AI uses but I never process that consequence when I use AI. I appreciated the comparison to how much a phone would charge as it put the usage in an easy to understand relation. It also made me think about efficiency in a ChatGPT response. Oftentimes, I get my answer then Chat goes on and on with information I may not need. When I was watching the answer generate and the energy accumulate, I wanted to jump in and say "that's enough!" "stop wasting resources!" So as powerful a tool AI is, we must be more conscientious with our usage, and understand the implications it has on our environment.

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## Teaching Artifacts

### Teaching Artifact #4: Student-led research project between UCLA and the Antioquia School of Engineering

The following screenshots and photos show the experience of UCLA students in Medellín (Colombia), during the field visits of the 100,000 Strong in the Americas Innovation Fund grant. Results of this research project can also be found in the organization's website, the short report written by our department at UCLA, the final report written by the students, and the slides for the final presentation.

a) Screenshot of the proposal submitted to the environmental science practicum director after securing the grant funds, in which I described the objectives and activities of this student-led project:

**B. Objectives**

This project has three main goals:

1. Build capacities of a diverse cohort of undergraduate students to understand and assess the implementation of context-based and culturally sensitive community solar projects.
2. Promote virtual and in-person collaboration and exchange opportunities between undergraduate students in Colombia (EIA University) and California (UCLA).
3. Showcase the acquired awareness, skills, and knowledge with collaborative writing and outreach activities.

**C. Timeline and Activities**

In this project, students will:

- Learn about the concepts and challenges related to the just energy transition and community energy projects, as well as an overview of the skills required to conduct a research project in this field.
- Design a case study research project, under the guidance of their university advisors.
- Conduct in-person visits to community energy projects in Medellín and in Los Angeles, gather data, and meet with stakeholders (government, utilities, nonprofits, and communities).
- Write a report with the findings of their research project, ideas for future collaboration between the two universities, and recommendations for the stakeholders.

b) Compilation of pictures from the UCLA visit to Medellín (above) and the Colombian students' visit to LA (below)






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## Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students

**Name:** Fiorella Hunter

### Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (45 words)

I worked closely with Sebastian in multiple capacities: as his research assistant on the Let Communities Lead project focusing on Colombian rural energy solutions, as his student in ENV 178: Energy in Society, and most significantly, as his advisee during my Environmental Science practicum project.

### In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words)

At UCLA, with its sea of students and short quarters, I hadn't experienced real mentorship in my first two years. When I approached Sebastian after his guest lecture, I was prepared for the usual ghost period after the 'send me an email' response. Instead, he met my curiosity with genuine interest for a conversation that completely caught me off guard. Within a week, he had made time to meet and invited me to join his research project. I felt seen and inspired to explore my potential.

His contagious enthusiasm for research and learning creates a ripple effect among students, inspiring not just individual growth but fostering a collaborative learning environment. Working with Sebastian transformed my outlook on environmental science: my coursework wasn't just theory, but came alive with real-world applications and possibilities. Sebastian would remember details from conversations and send opportunities and internships that allowed me to learn through doing.

Through our interactions, I found myself more excited about my studies than I'd been in years, eager to engage in class discussions and dive deeper into my research interests. Sebastian showed me what it means to be truly passionate about one's field, and inspired me to find it for myself.

### Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (178 words)

During our 9-month practicum project, our student-led team hit a wall. While other advisors stepped back to let us solve our own obstacles, Sebastian recognized our growing frustration. He paused the meeting, gave us a quick break, then gathered us around the

whiteboard. The simple act of visualizing our research and reorganizing it showed us how much we'd accomplished and illuminated our path forward.

Even more remarkably, Sebastian excels at personalizing education for each student. When I shared how my Peruvian heritage influenced my environmental interests through concepts of reciprocity between humans and earth, he responded with genuine understanding rather than judgment. Throughout our mentorship, he consistently connected 'Western' concepts like energy systems back to my interest in environmental symbiosis. Whether through targeted comments in lectures, sharing relevant articles, or brief post-class discussions, he made the material personally meaningful. Most impressively, he did this for everyone, weaving individual students' interests into his teaching, demonstrating his exceptional ability to make learning relevant to each person's unique perspective. Like me, students gain confidence knowing they have someone in their corner.

### Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words).

There are TAs that come to class with effective material prepared, answer all your emails, and host productive office hours, but you cannot teach someone how to create an environment that excites students. Sebastian creates an environment that fosters motivation and encourages students to share their opinions. He inspires us to take on more responsibility than we thought possible, pushing us to be better versions of ourselves by igniting our own drive. While these words capture only a fraction of his impact, I cannot think of anyone more deserving of this award; I'm beyond grateful to have learned from him.

**Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation**

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

**Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation**

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Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, LOS ANGELES
**UCLA Institute of the Environment and Sustainability**

BERKELEY • DAVIS • IRVINE • LOS ANGELES • RIVERSIDE • SAN DIEGO • SAN FRANCISCO SANTA BARBARA • SANTA CRUZ

Institute of the Environment and
Sustainability
La Kretz Hall, Suite 300
619 Charles E. Young Dr. East
Los Angeles, CA
90095

February 2. 2026

To whom it may concern,

I strongly support Sebastián Solarte-Caicedo's nomination for the UCLA Teaching and Learning Center's Distinguished Teaching Awards. I have had the privilege of working with Sebastián as my Teaching Assistant for *Environment 155: Energy and Society in a Time of Climate Change* since Fall 2022, and I can attest to his four-year commitment to shaping an innovative course that centers student experience while raising critical awareness of the most pressing social and ecological injustices embedded in contemporary energy systems.

Since its inception, Sebastián has been deeply involved in shaping the course syllabus. We have engaged in extensive discussions about designing a course that incorporates innovative pedagogical approaches and moves beyond conventional learning strategies and assessments. Together, we have explored ways to integrate recommendations and resources from UCLA units such as the Teaching and Learning Center and the Center for Accessible Education. In these conversations, Sebastián consistently advocates for students, anticipating potential challenges and proposing alternatives that foster an inclusive learning environment responsive to diverse approaches to learning.

Sebastián has also played an active role in proposing and implementing alternative assignments, often drawing on feedback from previous cohorts. Each year, we collaboratively refine the rubrics and grading criteria to better align with the course's objectives and evolving expectations, and his contributions are consistently instrumental. Most recently, he designed and implemented two highly successful active-learning activities (a written assignment engaging students in the use and critical discussion of Artificial Intelligence, and a structured debate on nuclear energy) both of which were very positively received by the class.

These efforts exemplify Sebastián's intellectual curiosity and sustained commitment to becoming a more inclusive and equitable instructor, continuously improving the courses in which he is involved, and expanding the learning opportunities available to his students. Another clear example of this commitment is his initiative in organizing a collaborative team of researchers from my research center, the California Center for Sustainable Communities, and the Antioquia

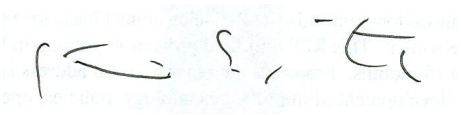
School of Engineering in Colombia to apply for a grant from the 100K Strong in the Americas initiative. This grant enabled American and Colombian undergraduate students to design and conduct fieldwork in Los Angeles and Medellín, broadening students' global awareness while grounding their learning in real-world contexts. Without Sebastián's leadership, this student-centered, international learning opportunity would not have been possible for UCLA students.

Sebastían always surprises me, anticipating what needs to be done, and either approaching me about the next step, or simply taking care of it. As an instructor, he has really facilitated my work, freeing me to do the teaching, to explore new materials – though he also flags it too – and to ensuring students feel nurtured. I am truly impressed at the way he has established grading rubrics, reducing student anxiety about fairness. Truly he is the most exceptional TA I have ever had.

In sum, Sebastián's dedication has been an invaluable addition to my course and, more importantly, has significantly enriched the learning experience of our students.

Please feel free to reach out with any questions.

Best regards,



Stephanie Pincetl
Professor
Director, California Center for Sustainable Communities
Chair, Ph.D. in Environment and Sustainability
UCLA Institute of the Environment and Sustainability